

Civilian Vulnerability and Systemic Human Rights Violations

Human Rights Monitoring Report in Six High Risk Regions in Ethiopia

Reporting Period: January – March 2026

Executive Summary

During the first quarter of 2026, civilian protection in Ethiopia broke down critically. Expanding its monitoring operations to six high-risk regions Amhara, Oromia, Tigray, Somali, Afar, and Gambella OJAH documented 102 unique, verified incidents. This dataset reveals a nationwide pattern where political and military objectives are consistently prioritized over the fundamental right to life.

Key Findings

- **High-Lethality Tactics:** Nearly half of all documented cases (47.1%) involved lethal force, including heavy artillery and drone strikes. State forces were the primary perpetrators in 48% of these incidents.
- **Administrative Negligence:** Security forces in Gambella, Afar, and Tigray repeatedly ignored early warnings of violence or permitted humanitarian aid blockages to persist under a posture of technical neutrality.
- **Targeting Community Anchors:** Perpetrators systematically targeted farmers, laborers, healthcare workers, and educators to dismantle local community resilience.
- **Weaponization of Scarcity:** Active humanitarian blockades continue to cause daily starvation inside internally displaced persons (IDP) camps.

OJAH calls for an immediate halt to attacks on civilians, the restoration of media freedom, and the protection of essential infrastructure. This monitor serves as an evidentiary record demanding immediate

OJAH
documented 102 verified
incidents across Amhara,
Oromia, Tigray, Somali, Afar,
and Gambella, identifying a
nationwide pattern of
human rights violations

accountability and peaceful conflict resolution.



Report Context

This Q1 2026 monitor, prepared by the Organization for Justice and Accountability in the Horn of Africa (OJAH), documents human rights violations across Ethiopia to preserve evidence for future justice, accountability, and policy reform.

- **Evolution of Monitoring:** What began as a pilot program in early 2025 (covering Tigray and Amhara) expanded to Afar and Oromia in late 2025, and grew to include Somali and Gambella in 2026. OJAH now monitors six high-risk regions to provide a cohesive national perspective.
- **Unified Dataset:** We analyze 102 unique incidents as a single dataset to identify nationwide patterns of violence, highlighting areas where local administration and protective forces have collapsed or been weaponized against civilians.
- **Civilian Impact:** Key documented trends reveal the systematic targeting of community anchors—including farmers, laborers, teachers, healthcare workers, activists, and journalists—alongside severe armed displacement and humanitarian blockades.
- **Evidence Standards:** All findings are based on secure, primary evidence collected by embedded field teams and triangulated with independent sources to ensure rigorous accuracy.

Method

OJAH employed a rigorous documentation methodology across all six regions as a unified, consolidated effort.

Data Collection and Management

- Enables identification of national trends crossing regional borders and correlation of perpetrator behavior across zones
- Ensures uniform verification thresholds and forensic detail for all documented incidents

Field Network and Security

- Local documenters embedded within communities conduct private interviews with survivors and witnesses
- All data transmitted through encrypted, secure channels to protect identities of witnesses and

field staff

Verification Process

- Embedded local documenters gather survivor and witness testimonies via secure, encrypted channels. All incidents are triangulated against at least two independent sources (civil society, local administrative communications, and humanitarian agencies).

Analysis and Categorization

- Senior investigators analyze verified incidents to identify specific violations and assess impact
- Violations categorized by type, strategic intent, and whether involving direct violence, omission, or regulatory weaponization

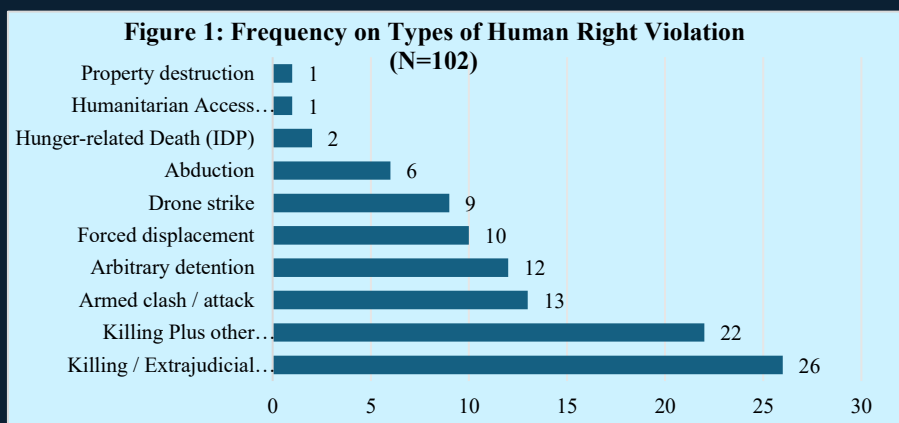
Limitations

- Findings represent a baseline; actual scale of atrocities likely significantly higher

Findings

Human Rights Violation Monitoring

Human rights monitoring across Ethiopia in Q1 2026 uncovered a pattern of escalating violence and systemic instability. OJAH documented 102 unique incidents suggesting a coordinated effort to suppress civilian voices and control populations through direct force and the denial of basic survival needs. While early months were marked by intense kinetic violence, the quarterly picture reveals a tactical shift toward silencing dissent through arrests and the quiet violence of humanitarian blockades.



Regional Distribution of Violations

The geographical spread of violations in Q1 2026 shows a shifting crisis. Active military violence in the highlands transitioned into systemic neglect and security vacuums in the regional peripheries.

Table 1: Regional Distribution of Violations from January to March 2026 (N-102).			
Region	Frequency	Percentage	Primary Incident Dynamics
Amhara	31	30.4%	Aerial warfare (drones), extrajudicial killings of laborers, and targeting of educators.
Oromia	21	20.6%	Displacement linked to urban megaprojects, rural drone strikes, and media crackdowns.
Tigray	15	14.7%	Detention of journalists and political figures, alongside famine-related deaths in IDP sites.
Somali	13	12.7%	Reports of institutionalized torture and weaponized neglect in drought-affected zones.
Gambella	13	12.7%	Urban ethnic fracturing and violence occurring in significant security vacuums.
Afar	9	8.8%	Kinetic border clashes, pastoralist mobility restrictions, and blocked aid access.
Total	102	100%	

Regional Highlights: Stories Behind the Data

The data illustrates the breadth of the crisis, while these highlights offer a deeper look into specific events defining the human rights landscape across Ethiopia in Q1 2026. These stories reveal a country where civilian life is increasingly caught between high-tech warfare, administrative overreach, and lethal neglect of those in need of protection.

1. Amhara Region

- Primary epicenter, accounting for over 30% of all documented incidents
- Mid-January drone strike in Sahala Seyem killed 36 people, including a healthcare professional
- Rise in abduction and killing of educators in North Wollo and East Gojjam
- Torture and death of Red Cross personnel in North Gondar marked a breakdown in humanitarian neutrality



2. Oromia Region

- Gender-Based Violence: Field teams documented a surge in conflict-related sexual violence during armed raids on rural villages. Incidents remain underreported due to infrastructure collapse and social stigma.
- Information Blackout: The state revoked the operating licenses of independent media outlets, including Addis Standard, to shield military operations and human rights abuses from public oversight.



3. Tigray Region

- War of attrition through denial of sustenance and silencing of dissent
- Hunger-related deaths surged in IDP camps like Hitsats, with 1,700 IDPs in critical condition
- Aid corridor blockages turned camps into zones of terminal vulnerability
- Arrests of veteran journalist Yohannes Birhane on March 18 and abductions of activists Birhane G/Giorgis and Shewit



4. Somali Region

- Institutionalized torture in detention facilities, including plastic bags filled with powdered pepper
- State resources diverted from drought relief to security expenditures, abandoning pastoralist communities



5. Afar Region

- Over 18,000 IDPs in Zones 2 and 4 denied food and medical care for the entire quarter
- Aid routes like the Abala/Abida corridor blocked by regional militias
- Military curfews prevented pastoralists from reaching grazing lands, driving families into artificial famine



6. Gambella Region

- Late February killing of 43 Nuer residents in Itang despite security forces receiving verified warnings
- Security structures split along ethnic lines following internal police assassinations
- Police transformed from protective body into competing militias, leaving urban residents vulnerable to targeted assaults



Q1 2026 witnessed violence targeting civilians through drone strikes, humanitarian blockades, mass displacements, gender-based violence, and attacks on community anchors, revealing a systematic breakdown of civilian protection across Ethiopia.

Perpetrators and Incident Patterns

Analyzing the relationship between those committing violations and their methods reveals the strategic nature of the current environment of impunity. Throughout the quarter (January–March), different actors utilize specific "tools" ranging from state-sponsored drone strikes to the silent failure of security forces to protect vulnerable groups.

*GOVERNMENT ACTORS REMAIN THE
PRIMARY DRIVERS OF RIGHTS VIOLATIONS*

- State Forces (48.0%): The primary driver of violations. Tactics range from lethal drone strikes and the arrest of journalists to "massacres by omission" (failing to intervene in predicted communal violence) and starvation in IDP camps via aid denial.
- Non-State Armed Groups (39.2%): Responsible for the highest volume of direct local attacks, characterized by rural raids, abductions for ransom, and systematic property destruction in contested zones.
- Unknown Perpetrators (12.8%): Heavily linked to abductions and property destruction. The state's failure to investigate and identify these actors entrenches impunity and fosters a pervasive climate of fear.

Strategic Targeting of Community Anchors

Violence is systematically directed at the social pillars sustaining community resilience:

- Professionals, Media Personnel, and Activists: Composing 24% of violations, journalists, teachers, and human rights defenders are targeted to create information blackouts.
- Economic Sabotage (Labor Segment): The execution of 17 agricultural workers in Awi, Amhara, and other targeted killings of farmers were deployed to paralyze rural productivity and cut off survival means.

- Vulnerability as a Weapon: IDPs and marginalized ethnic groups are subjected to intentional food and medical deprivation, turning physical dependency into a tool of control.

Conclusion

The Q1 2026 monitoring results reveal a severe crisis where civilian protection is consistently subordinated to political and military objectives. The 102 documented incidents ranging from aid blockades in Tigray and Afar to widespread displacement in Oromia and security vacuums in Gambella represent a systemic erosion of the social contract. Without immediate accountability and structural reforms, a persistent culture of impunity will continue to deepen this humanitarian crisis across Ethiopia.

Call to Action

OJAH demands a unified, immediate response to this nationwide crisis:

- End Attacks on Civilians: All warring parties must immediately stop targeting key community anchors, including farmers, laborers, healthcare workers, and educators.
- Exert Real Pressure: The international community must move beyond diplomatic concern and apply concrete pressure to force transparent, legal accountability.
- Prioritize Human Rights: Military and political negotiations must establish the right to food, freedom of movement, and a free press as non-negotiable starting points for any national dialogue.

Roadmap for Justice

To break the prevailing cycle of violence and impunity and initiate a credible process of restoration, the Organization for Justice and Accountability in the Horn of Africa proposes the following immediate actions:

1. Federal and Regional Governments

- Halt Airstrikes in Civilian Zones: Immediately cease the use of heavy artillery and military airstrikes in civilian-populated and agricultural zones.
- Restore Civilian Administration: Transition away from military-led Command Posts in borderlands and rural woredas to unblock aid and restore pastoralist mobility.
- Investigate Gambella Negligence: Authorize the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission to independently investigate the security apparatus's failure to prevent the Itang massacre, holding derelict officials accountable.
- Reinstate Media Licenses: Restore the operating licenses of Addis Standard and other suspended independent media outlets to lift the information blackout.

2. Non-State Armed Groups

- Cease Infrastructure Destruction: Immediately stop targeting public services, administrative offices, and agricultural hubs.
- Guarantee Humanitarian Access: Provide unconditional, unhindered passage for humanitarian groups trying to reach vulnerable populations in IDP camps and drought-stricken zones.

3. International Community

- Support Local Evidence Collection: Direct resources to local human rights defenders and civil society organizations documenting abuses to preserve evidence for future legal proceedings.
- Demand the Lifting of Blockades: Use diplomatic and economic leverage to force the immediate lifting of humanitarian blockades in Tigray and Afar.
- Prepare International Justice Avenues: Because domestic channels are compromised, international legal bodies must actively prepare cases to break the cycle of systemic impunity.

